



Subscribe from €2.30 per week

Log in

Benefits scandal

The Rutte III cabinet falls over the benefits scandal

The third Rutte cabinet has ultimately fallen over the childcare benefits scandal. On Friday, the team of ministers decided to resign collectively.



Prime Minister Mark Rutte makes a phone call in the Torentje on Thursday evening. EPA

Niels Markus January 15, 2021, 13:33



To share

[Tensions within the coalition](#) have been rising in recent days . The VVD, CDA, D66, and ChristenUnie had to find an answer to the damning findings of the Van Dam Parliamentary Committee



Front page



Newspaper



Most read



Listen



Categories

month that tens of thousands of parents have suffered 'unprecedented injustice,' that the principles of the rule of law have been violated, and that the Cabinet, Parliament, and the judiciary are responsible for this.

Advertentie

Over the past few weeks, the cabinet has been working on a substantive response [to the report](#), in an attempt to convince society that something like this will never and can never happen again. But the discussions on this within the cabinet ultimately also revolved around the inevitable question of what political consequences this affair must have.

Extra pressure due to Asscher's resignation

Initially, Prime Minister Rutte was convinced that the resignation of his third cabinet would not be necessary. Coalition partners thought otherwise. The feeling among the CDA, D66, and CU that there was no other option but to step down was reinforced by [Lodewijk Asscher's decision](#) to withdraw as lead candidate for the PvdA.

The fall of the cabinet appears at first glance to be primarily a symbolic gesture towards the many affected parents. After all, the parliamentary elections are just around the corner; the campaign recess begins in four weeks, meaning the team of ministers would de facto operate as a caretaker cabinet from that moment on.

Nevertheless, the resignation comes at an extremely inconvenient time. The country is still in the midst of the coronavirus crisis, and the British mutation of the virus is causing Prime Minister Rutte

remain in lockdown longer and that there is a possibility that a curfew will be introduced next week—a topic that was until recently hardly open for discussion within the cabinet and in Parliament.

Rutte III will therefore have to continue combating this crisis in a caretaker capacity. That need [not be a problem](#). There is a coronavirus law in place that allows the cabinet to continue taking drastic measures. The Prime Minister already stated on Tuesday that if his cabinet were to become caretaker, it would have to be 'mentally missionary' in these times. He also implicitly called upon opposition leaders to maintain a constructive stance in tackling the virus.

Wiebes did not want to bear the blame for the affair alone.

In recent weeks, the story circulated that only VVD Minister of Economic Affairs Eric Wiebes would resign in response to the childcare benefits scandal. At the time, as State Secretary for Finance, he bore responsibility for the functioning of the Tax and Customs Administration. Coalition partners, led by D66, reportedly considered this too meager a gesture. Wiebes himself also indicated that he does not want to bear the blame for the affair alone. The report by the Van Dam Commission shows that multiple government officials, across multiple areas, bear responsibility for the parents' misery.

Advertentie

Last week, the VVD hinted that it did not necessarily consider resignation necessary. VVD parliamentary leader Klaas Dijkhoff called resignation on NPO Radio 1 just before the elections 'a gesture of high symbolic value'. Behind closed doors, Rutte echoed this sentiment.

would await. A large part of the opposition would support a motion of no confidence next week regardless. The question was what the PvdA and SGP would do. PvdA leader Lodewijk Asscher, as Minister of Social Affairs, played a major role in the childcare benefits scandal himself. His resignation means that the PvdA parliamentary group has a free hand in the debate to support such a motion of no confidence.

Moreover, it was by no means certain whether all MPs from the coalition parties were willing to keep the cabinet afloat. Rutte wanted to avoid such a bloody debate, resulting in even more loss of face, at all costs.

Advertentie

[Read the full statement by outgoing Prime Minister Mark Rutte here.](#)



Help us by sharing your experience: [Give feedback](#)

